

Physical Education

Year 3

Cambridge Primary

Student Manual



Physical Education • Year 3

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Safety, and it is not a formality. This is a Physical Education book, so almost every task moves a body through a space. Every task assumes a teacher present, a space checked before the lesson, and apparatus set out and tested by an adult. The teacher carries out their own risk assessment and follows the school's safety policy. Where a task carries a particular risk, the book says so on the page in an orange **Stay safe** panel. Those panels are instructions, not advice.

Inclusion. Every comparison in this book asks a pupil to look at their own earlier attempt. No task ranks one pupil against another, and no task requires a particular body to succeed. Teachers adapt distances, heights and timings freely: the objective is control, not size.

The three big days. The dates on the next page but one are the Prime School plan for the academic year 2026/27. Confirm them against the school calendar before the year starts, because a term end can move.

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This edition carries Unit 1, at the Cinder Track. Units 2 to 6 follow in the complete book.

The year at a glance

Three terms. Three big days. Every one of them uses something you learn in this book.

TERM 1 ENDS

Athletics Day

December 2026



- Sprint
- Relays
- Standing long jump
- Target throw
- Obstacle race

TERM 2 ENDS

Football Day

March 2027



- Dribbling in and out of the cones race
- Passing accuracy game
- Penalty shootout
- Full game

TERM 3 ENDS

Multi-sports Day

June 2027



- Bowling
- Sack racing
- Bean bag throw
- Water pong, a ball thrown into a row of water cups

What Unit 1 gives you for all three days

Every one of the fourteen activities above is a movement done **on purpose**, and three of the four things you learn at the Cinder Track show up in all of them.

FROM UNIT 1	ON ATHLETICS DAY	ON FOOTBALL DAY	ON MULTI-SPORTS DAY
1.1 practising until a movement is smooth	the standing long jump, where a smooth landing wins it	passing accuracy, which is ten quiet repetitions	the bean bag throw
1.2 joining movements with no stop	the obstacle race, which is all joins	dribbling in and out of the cones	sack racing, hop after hop

FROM UNIT 1	ON ATHLETICS DAY	ON FOOTBALL DAY	ON MULTI-SPORTS DAY
1.3 choosing your speed and level on purpose	the sprint, and pacing a relay leg	knowing when to slow down with the ball	bowling, where hard is usually wrong
1.4 keeping control when the ground changes	running on grass instead of clay	a full game, where nothing stays still	water pong and the bowling lane

✧ DID YOU KNOW?

Look down the Athletics Day column. The **sprint** is the only activity there where being fastest is the whole answer. In the other four, a pupil who moves smoothly and knows exactly what their body is doing will beat a pupil who is simply quick.

That is not a comforting thing to say. It is the reason this book spends its first ground on control rather than on speed.

Welcome to the meadow track

You already know how to run.

You learned that in Year 1, out in the meadow, along with jumping, hopping, skipping, landing softly and stopping where you meant to. Last year you took all of it onto a marked court and played in a team.

So this year is not about learning new movements. It is about something harder and much more interesting: **doing a movement you already know, better than you did it last week, and being able to say what changed.**

That is what the white lines are for. A measured ground lets you find out.

Here is the difference. In Year 1, "I can jump" was the whole answer. This year the answer sounds more like this: *I can land my jump without wobbling, and I can go*

straight into a roll afterwards, and if you ask me to do it slowly I can do that too.
Same jump. Far more control.



The track before anybody arrives. Six lanes brushed flat, a rake against the fence and one stopwatch left hanging on the rail. Look at the white lines: everything in this book happens between them.

THE FIELD · SIX GROUNDS, ONE FOR EACH UNIT

- 1 **The Cinder Track.** Practising a movement until it is smooth, joining movements together, and keeping control when the ground changes.
- 2 **The Watching Post.** Willow's place. Words for what a body actually did, and how to judge whether it worked.
- 3 **The Wide Meadow.** Finding movements nobody showed you, and moving to say something.
- 4 **The Team Field.** Your job, everybody else's job, and taking a turn at leading.
- 5 **The Kit Shed.** Sharing a space and a set of equipment safely, and what fair play really means.
- 6 **The Long Hill.** What happens inside you while you move, and what a moving body needs.

This book is ground one. The other five follow.

Three jobs, and you will do all of them

Almost every task in this book needs three people, because you cannot watch yourself move.

JOB	WHAT YOU DO	WHAT YOU MUST NOT DO
Mover	Do the movement, properly, as many times as the task says	Rush it to look quick, or change it halfway through
Timer	Count, or time, and say the number out loud	Guess, round the number kindly, or start the watch early
Watcher	Look at one thing only, and say what you saw	Say "good", which tells the mover nothing at all



Three jobs at once. Sorrel is moving, Bramble is timing and reading the watch, and Willow is writing down what she saw. Nobody is standing about, which is the point of working in threes.

Swap jobs every time. The watcher's job is the one most people are worst at, and it is the one that makes you better at the other two.

✧ DID YOU KNOW?

The **watcher** is the job nobody wants and everybody needs. Ask any of the six which job they find hardest and five of them will say watching, because a watcher has to keep their mouth shut, look at one thing, and then describe it without saying whether they liked it.

Willow is the exception. She would rather watch than move, which is why her notes turn up all through this book as the model for yours.

Meet the six

The same six as last year, a year older.

Pip

Red squirrel, sage vest. Quick, and always first to try. This year he is finding out that his fastest attempt and his best attempt are not the same attempt.

Bramble

Badger, slate tracksuit. Strong and steady, and he never rushes. He holds the stopwatch, and he reads out the number that is actually on it.

Sorrel

Hare. The fastest of all of them. A hare has one brilliant speed, and this year she is learning that slow, low and smooth are also things you can be good at.

Tuft

Hedgehog. The smallest and the most careful. He reads the space before he moves into it, which is why he is almost never in anybody's way.



Willow

Barn owl. She watches, from up on the fence post where she can see the whole shape of a movement. She is the reason this book keeps asking you to say what you saw instead of saying whether you liked it.

When you see her notes in a flint-grey panel, that is Willow telling you exactly what one body did. Copy the way she says it, not just what she says.

Rowan

Otter. Happiest in a group, and very good at giving everybody a job. If a task has four parts and six people, ask Rowan.

None of the six is better than the others. Each one is good at a different thing, which is exactly how a class works, and it is why the tasks keep making you swap.

How to use this book

Every ground is built the same way, so once you know the shapes you always know where you are.

SHAPE	WHAT IT MEANS
Come out to the track	A question to talk about before you move. There is no wrong answer yet.
What happened	The real problem for this topic. Everything after it is you sorting that out.
On this ground you will	What you will be able to do by the end. Come back and check.
Warm up	Two minutes, straight in, and it is never optional in this subject.
Do you remember?	Something from Year 1 or Year 2 that you are about to need again.
Learn	The marked ground and the new idea. Read the drawing first, then the words.
Watch me try	One attempt, taken slowly, with the reason for each part.
Your turn	Your work. Move first, then write, draw and tick in the book.
Willow's own notes	What a watcher actually wrote down. A model for your own.
Stay safe	Orange. An instruction, not a suggestion. Read it before you move.
The equipment you need	Fetch this before you start, so nobody stands about.
Did you know?	A true thing worth knowing that is not in any test.
Go a little further	For when you have finished and want more.
Track challenge	Harder. Expect to need three attempts.
The meadow games	The project at the end of the ground.
How did it go?	You judging your own work, honestly.
Look what I can do	The tick list. Only tick what is true today.
Words we used	Every new word, with its meaning.

The marked grounds

Wherever you see a warm clay panel with white chalk lines on it, you are looking at **the space seen from above**, the way Willow sees it. The marks always mean the same thing.

MARK	MEANS
a solid white line	a line you may not cross
a dashed white line	the route a body travels
a white ring	where a body starts, or stops
a small cross	a cone, a marker or a spot
the ticks down the left edge	paces, counted

Writing in this book

You are meant to. The pale boxes, the ruled lines and the timing tables are yours. Use a pencil, because your second attempt is usually a different number from your first, and that is the whole point.

Getting set up

You do not need everything at once. Each ground tells you what to fetch.

Your track kit

- soft indoor shoes, or bare feet, whichever your teacher says for the space
- a stopwatch, or one clock everybody can see
- eight cones, or eight of anything that stands up and does not roll away
- two skipping ropes
- a hoop
- chalk, or a roll of low-tack tape, for marking a line on the floor
- a pencil, because half of this book gets written in
- five other people, which is the most important item on the list



Your kit, laid out. Not one thing here needs a screen. Count them against the list: shoes, a watch, four cones, two ropes, a hoop, a stub of chalk and a pencil. The chalk does most of the work in Unit 1.

Ground rules

- 1 Walk into the space. Everybody walks in, every time, however exciting it is.
- 2 Look before you move. Tuft is right about this and he is right every lesson.
- 3 One mover at a time in a marked lane, unless the task says otherwise.
- 4 The timer says the number that is on the watch, not the number that would be kind.
- 5 A watcher says what they **saw**, never whether it was good.
- 6 Put the equipment back where it came from, at the end, without being asked.
- 7 Stop the moment you hear "stop". Not after this one. Now.

STAY SAFE

Before anybody moves, check three things and say them out loud:

The floor. Dry, clear, nothing to trip on, nothing to slide on. **The edges.**

Nothing hard within two paces of any line you might run past. **The apparatus.** Every bench, mat and hoop set out and tested by an adult, not by you.

If any of the three is wrong, you tell an adult and you do not begin.

How every task runs

Almost every task in this book has the same six steps. Learn them once and you will never have to be told the order again.

- 1 **Fetch.** Read *The equipment you need* at the top of the topic and collect it before anybody moves. One person fetches for the three of you.
- 2 **Mark the ground.** Chalk or tape the lines the task asks for. Walk the space once, empty, and move anything you would rather not run into.
- 3 **Agree the one thing.** Say out loud what the mover is trying to change, and what the watcher is going to look at. If you cannot say it in one short sentence, it is not one thing yet.
- 4 **Go.** The mover moves, the timer counts or times, the watcher looks. Nobody talks during a go except the timer, and the timer only says the number.
- 5 **Swap.** Every three goes, change jobs. By the end of the task all three of you will have moved, timed and watched.
- 6 **Put back.** Equipment goes back where it came from, chalk gets wiped or the tape lifted, and the space is left as you found it.

The step people skip is 3, and skipping it costs the whole task, because a watcher who does not know what to look at will fall back on saying "that was good".

✧ DID YOU KNOW?

Rule 4 is the one everybody breaks, and it is worth knowing why it matters. A timer who takes a tenth of a second off to be nice has not been kind: they have thrown away the only evidence the mover had that their practice worked. Numbers are how you find out. A kind number is a useless number.

If something is hard

Some of these tasks will be hard for you and easy for the person next to you, and some will be the other way round. That is not a problem to be hidden. It is information, and it is the only kind this book actually cares about.

So when a task does not fit you, **change the task**. Ask for any of these:

- a shorter lane, or fewer paces to count
- a lower bench, a wider line, or the hoop on the floor instead of held up
- more goes, or a rest between goes
- to be the timer or the watcher first, and the mover afterwards
- the movement done sitting, kneeling or supported, if travelling is difficult

Every one of those still teaches the same thing, because the thing being taught is **control**, and control has nothing to do with how big or how fast you are. A pupil who holds a slow, low crossing all the way across has met the objective. A pupil who is quickest and cannot slow down has not.

Asking for a change is not giving up and it is not cheating. It is exactly what Rowan does when a task has four parts and six people: he changes the shape of the task so that everybody has a job. Do the same for yourself.

Looking after the kit

The equipment in this book is shared with every other class in the school, so two habits matter more than they sound.

Count it back in. Eight cones went out, eight cones come back. It takes ten seconds and it is the difference between the next class having a lesson and not.

Say when something breaks. A split hoop, a frayed rope, a bench with a wobble in it: tell an adult the moment you notice, not at the end. Nobody is ever in trouble for reporting a broken thing, and somebody could be hurt by a quiet one.

UNIT 1 · CINDER TRACK

1

Moving well

You already know how to run, jump and land. This ground is about doing it better than you did it last week, and being able to say what changed.

At the Cinder Track you practise one movement until it is smooth, join movements into a sequence, change the speed and the level on purpose, and keep all of that control when somebody puts a bench in your way.



Picture 1.0 The Cinder Track on an ordinary afternoon. Pip is the only one moving. Bramble has the watch, Willow is up on the post where she can see the whole run, and Sorrel, Rowan and Tuft are waiting their turn. Five of the six are working, and only one of them is running.

✓ ON THIS GROUND YOU WILL

- ✓ practise one movement on purpose, and say what got smoother
- ✓ join three movements into a sequence with no stop in the middle
- ✓ perform the same movement fast, slow, high and low, deliberately
- ✓ keep your control when the apparatus and the space change

○ Come out to the track

Think of something your body does well. Catching. Skipping. Running round a bend.

Now answer a harder question. **How did it get good?**

Almost nobody can remember. It got good quietly, from doing it over and over without paying much attention. This unit does the same thing loudly, on purpose, so that you can see it happening and make it happen faster.

UNIT 1 - TOPIC 1.1**Making a movement smoother****■ THE EQUIPMENT YOU NEED**

Two cones, chalk or tape for one line, a stopwatch or a wall clock, and a pencil. Work in threes.

✦ WARM UP

Walk briskly anywhere in the space for one minute, changing direction whenever you meet somebody, without touching anybody. Then roll your shoulders back five times and rise onto your toes five times.

Now stand still. Your body is warm, your ankles are awake, and you are ready. Cold practice is wasted practice.

◆ WHAT HAPPENED

Pip does a standing jump. It is a big jump, and he lands with a thump, and his hands go out sideways to stop himself falling over.

He does it nine more times. Every one of them is a big jump with a thump and the hands going out.

Bramble says, "That was ten jumps." Willow says, "That was the same jump ten times."

They are both right, and Willow's version is the useful one.

► Learn

Doing a movement ten times is not the same as practising it.

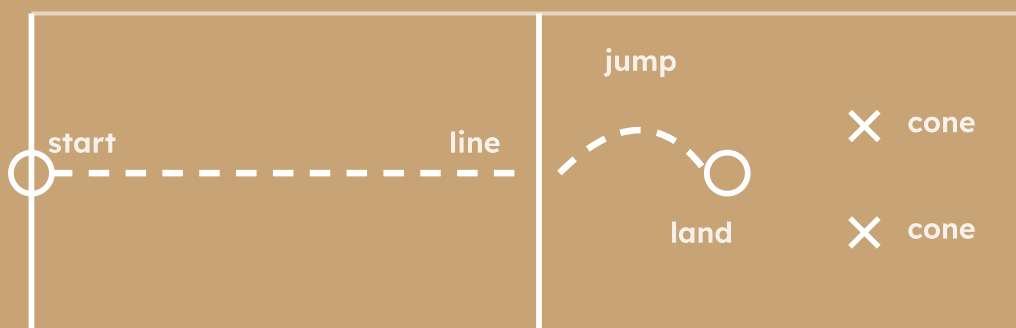
Practice means repeating a movement *with something you are trying to change*. Without that, you are only keeping fit, which is fine, but nothing gets smoother.

Three things make a practice work.

IT MUST HAVE	WHICH MEANS
One thing to change	Not "jump better". "Land with my knees bent and my hands still."
A way to tell	A watcher looking at that one thing, or a number from the timer.
Enough goes	Three attempts tell you nothing. Ten start to tell you something.

A movement that has been practised properly looks **smooth**: it has no wasted wobble, no extra step, and no arm shooting out to save it. Smooth is not the same as fast. Smooth usually turns out to be faster anyway, which surprises people.

GROUND 1.1 · THE PRACTICE LANE



Solid white lines are the two lines you may not cross: the start and the take-off. The dashed line is Pip's route, a run-up and then one jump. The two crosses are cones, set beyond the landing ring so nobody runs into them.



One thing, and only one thing. This is what Pip is practising: knees bent, and both paws hanging quietly at his sides. Willow has already looked, and now she is writing it down. That is what makes it practice instead of just ten more jumps.

■ WATCH ME TRY

Pip tries again, this time properly. He picks **one** thing to change: *land with bent knees and still hands*. Willow watches only the hands. Bramble counts the wobbles.

GO	HANDS	WOBBLES	WHAT PIP CHANGED NEXT
1	shot out sideways	2	nothing yet, that was the first one
2	shot out sideways	2	bend the knees more on landing
3	one hand out	1	keep bending the knees
4	one hand out	1	look ahead, not down at the floor
5	still	0	nothing. Do that again.
6	still	0	nothing. Do that again.

Look at goes 5 and 6. When something works you do **not** change it. You repeat it until it is the thing your body does without being asked.

And look at go 4. Pip changed **one** thing at a time. If he had bent his knees, looked ahead and swung his arms differently all at once, and go 4 had come out smooth, he would not know which of the three had done it.

* WILLOW'S OWN NOTES

Go 1: hands out sideways, knees straight, landed heavy on the heels.

Go 5: hands stayed by his sides, knees bent, landed on the front of the feet and stopped dead.

Notice what Willow did not write. She did not write "much better". She wrote what the hands did, what the knees did and what the feet did. That is a watcher's job, and it is the whole reason Pip knew what to keep.



The same jump, ten times, on purpose. This is Pip's sixth go. Look only at his hands: they are hanging quietly at his sides, which is the one thing he set out to change. Bramble is down at the line with the watch, and the other three are watching that same detail.

✦ DID YOU KNOW?

Rosa Mota ran the marathon for Portugal. She won the Olympic gold medal in Seoul in 1988, in 2 hours 25 minutes and 40 seconds, and she won it by 13 seconds. She also won the world title in Rome in 1987 and the European title three times, in 1982, 1986 and 1990.

Eight years lie between her first European title and her last. She did not win those by discovering a new way to run. She won them by going back to the same movement, over and over, and refining it.

• YOUR TURN

- 1 Choose one movement you can already do: a standing jump, a hop on one foot, a two-handed catch, or a stop from a fast walk. Write it down, then write the **one thing** you will change.

I will practise

The one thing I will change is

- 2 Do it ten times. Your watcher looks only at your one thing. Your timer counts the wobbles. Fill this in as you go.

GO	WHAT THE WATCHER SAW	WOBBLES
1		
4		
7		
10		

- 3 Tick the one that is true.

- ☐ Go 10 was smoother than go 1.
- ☐ Go 10 was about the same as go 1.
- ☐ Go 10 was worse, because I got tired.

- 4 If you ticked the third box, that is a real answer and a useful one. Write what you would do differently next lesson.

→ **GO A LITTLE FURTHER**

Swap jobs with your watcher and do the whole thing again on **their** movement.

Then answer this out loud: was it easier to be the mover or the watcher?

Most people find watching harder, because saying exactly what a body did is a skill of its own. That is Unit 2, and it starts here.

UNIT 1 - TOPIC 1.2

Joining movements together

 THE EQUIPMENT YOU NEED

Chalk or tape for two lines, four cones, one mat if your space has them. Work in threes.

 DO YOU REMEMBER?

What are the three things that make a practice work, from 1.1?

One thing to change. _____

 WHAT HAPPENED

Sorrel can run, and she can jump, and she can turn. Rowan asks her to do all three, one after the other, across the hall.

She runs. She stops. She jumps. She stops. She turns.

"That was all three," says Sorrel.

"That was three movements and two stops," says Willow.

► Learn

A **sequence** is two or more movements joined so that there is no stop in the middle. The end of one movement becomes the start of the next.

The joins are the hard part, and they are the only part worth practising, because you can already do the movements.

IN A SEQUENCE, EACH MOVEMENT NEEDS	WHY
a finish that faces the right way	You cannot start a movement while facing the wrong direction
a finish that keeps some speed	A movement that stops dead has thrown away everything the last one gave it
a balance you can leave from	You can only move on from a position you are actually steady in

So the question at every join is the same: **can I begin the next movement from exactly where this one left me?** If the answer is no, the join is where you practise, not the movements.

GROUND 1.2 · THREE MOVEMENTS, TWO JOINS

The diagram illustrates a sequence of three movements: 'run', 'jump', and 'turn'. It begins with a 'start' circle, followed by a dashed line labeled 'run' leading to 'join 1'. From 'join 1', a dashed arc labeled 'jump' leads to 'join 2'. From 'join 2', a dashed line labeled 'turn' leads to a 'finish' circle. Two short upright chalk marks indicate the joins. The entire sequence is bounded by two horizontal lines.

The two short upright chalk marks are the joins. Everything before and after them is a movement Sorrel can already do. The join is the only new work on this page.

✧ DID YOU KNOW?

The triple jump is a sequence with two joins in it, and the rules name all three parts. An athlete makes a **hop**, landing on the same foot they took off from, then a **step** onto the other foot, then a **jump** into the sand. The three happen in one continuous run, without stopping.

Nelson Évora won the Olympic gold medal in the triple jump for Portugal in Beijing in 2008.

Three movements, two joins. Exactly what is on the ground drawing above, and exactly what you are about to practise across the hall.



Hop, step, jump. Sorrel doing the same thing a triple jumper does. Follow her feet left to right: she takes off from one foot and lands on it, then pushes on from the other foot, then leaps. Look at the footprints between the three pictures. There is no gap where she stopped.

■ WATCH ME TRY

Sorrel tries the run, jump, turn sequence again, and this time she practises only join 1.

Attempt 1. She runs, then stops, then jumps. *Join 1 failed: she arrived at the line with both feet together and no speed left.*

Attempt 2. She runs and takes off from the last running stride instead of stopping first. *Join 1 worked.* Now join 2 fails, because she lands the jump facing straight ahead and the turn needs her shoulder round.

Attempt 3. Same run, same take-off, and she lands the jump with her knees bent and her shoulders already beginning to turn. *Both joins worked.* One sequence, no stops.

Read attempt 2 again, because it is the most useful one. Fixing join 1 **revealed** a problem at join 2 that had been hiding behind the stop. That is normal. It is not going backwards.



The join, not the jump. Sorrel is off the ground and still travelling forward, because she took off from her last running stride instead of stopping first. Rowan is pointing at the join. Nothing in this picture has stopped.

• YOUR TURN

- 1 Build a sequence of three movements from this list. Write your three in order, then mark each of the two joins with an arrow.

run • jump • hop • skip • turn • roll • balance • stop

OUR SEQUENCE	
1	
2	
3	

Two joins. Mark them with an arrow.

- 2 Run it three times. After each go, the watcher says which join was weaker. Write the weaker join, not the whole sequence.

GO	THE WEAKER JOIN WAS
1	
2	
3	

- 3 Draw your route on the ground below. Use the marks you learned in *How to use this book*: a dashed line for the route, a ring for the start and the finish, and a short upright mark at each join.

OUR ROUTE, SEEN FROM ABOVE

- 4 Tick every one that is true of your third go.
- ☐ There was no stop in the middle.
 - ☐ I finished facing the way I meant to.
 - ☐ I could have added a fourth movement straight afterwards.

▲ TRACK CHALLENGE

Perform your sequence so that a watcher who has never seen it can write down all three movements **and** both joins, without asking you a single question.

If they miss one, do not explain it. Change the sequence so it explains itself, and try again. A sequence that needs talking through is a sequence that is not finished.

UNIT 1 - TOPIC 1.3

Fast, slow, high, low

■ THE EQUIPMENT YOU NEED

Chalk or tape for two lines, six cones, a drum or a tambourine if your teacher has one. Work in threes.

✦ WARM UP

Travel from one side of the space to the other four times, on your teacher's signal: once as fast as you safely can, once as slowly as you possibly can, once as tall as you can, and once as low as you can.

The slow one is the hardest. Almost everybody speeds up in the middle.

◆ WHAT HAPPENED

Sorrel is asked to cross the hall slowly.

She sets off slowly, gets bored halfway, and arrives at the far side at her normal speed without noticing she has changed.

"You went slowly," says Tuft, "for about four paces."

► Learn

The same movement can be done in many different ways. The way you do it is called its **dynamics**.

There are four dials, and you can turn each one without changing the movement itself.

DIAL	TURN IT DOWN	TURN IT UP
Speed	slowly, in your own time	quickly, at full pace
Level	low, close to the floor	high, tall, up on the toes
Size	small, tight, contained	large, stretched, reaching
Force	light, quiet, gentle	strong, firm, powerful

Turning a dial **on purpose and keeping it there** is the skill. Sorrel did not fail because she cannot go slowly. She failed because she did not keep the dial where she put it.



One hedgehog, four settings. Tuft travelling four different ways. Tall and stretched, then low and flat, then large reaching strides, then small tight steps. It is the same hedgehog and the same journey every time. Only the dial has moved.

There is a second half to this, and it is about the space. Where you travel matters as much as how.

IN THE SPACE YOU CAN CHANGE	FOR EXAMPLE
direction	forwards, backwards, sideways, diagonally
pathway	a straight line, a curve, a zigzag
where you are	near a wall, out in the middle, close to a partner

GROUND 1.3 · ONE ROUTE, FOUR DYNAMICS

FAST



dashes close together

SLOW



dashes far apart

HIGH



same route, up tall

LOW, STRONG



same route, thick line

Four grounds, one route. Look only at the chalk: close dashes mean fast, spread dashes mean slow, and a thick line means strong. The zigzag never changes. Everything else does.

■ WATCH ME TRY

Tuft crosses the hall four times on the same zigzag, changing one dial each time, and Bramble times him.

GO	DIAL SET TO	TIME	DID HE KEEP IT THERE?
1	fast	6 s	yes
2	slow	14 s	no, quick over the last two corners
3	slow, second try	21 s	yes
4	low	11 s	yes, knees bent the whole way

Compare go 2 with go 3. Seven whole seconds separate them, on the same route, with the same instruction. Go 2 was not slow. It only started slow.

This is why the timer matters in this topic. "Slowly" is an opinion. Twenty-one seconds is a fact.

✦ DID YOU KNOW?

A European hare can run at about 70 kilometres an hour. Sorrel, who is a hare, is faster than anybody else in the meadow and always has been.

That is one dial, turned all the way up, and it is the only setting a hare really needs in the wild, because a hare escapes by outrunning things in the open.

You are not a hare. In a hall, in a game and in a gymnastics sequence, the useful skill is being able to put the dial anywhere you like and leave it there.



The same crossing, four ways. Sorrel is going low and slow, the setting she finds hardest. Now look at the chalk under her: her path curves wide around the cone, because a body held that low cannot turn sharply. She did not choose that. The dial chose it for her.

• YOUR TURN

- 1 Mark a zigzag route with four cones. Cross it four times, changing one dial each time. Your timer writes the time; your watcher writes whether you kept the dial where you put it.

GO	DIAL SET TO	TIME	KEPT IT THERE?
1	fast	_____	_____
2	slow	_____	_____
3	high	_____	_____
4	low	_____	_____

2 Which two of your four times are furthest apart?

Go _____ and go _____

3 Now do the hardest one again and try to make it more extreme. Slower than slowly. Lower than low.

New time _____

4 Match each instruction to the dial it changes. Write the dial in the box.

INSTRUCTION	DIAL
"Cross the hall like a heavy giant."	
"Make yourself as small as a mouse and travel."	
"Go so slowly I cannot see you moving."	
"Travel on your toes with your arms stretched up."	

* WILLOW'S OWN NOTES

Go 1, fast: shoulders forward, arms driving, cut the corners tight.

Go 4, low: knees bent all the way across, back flat, took the corners wide because a low body cannot turn sharply.

Willow has spotted something the mover did not: going low **forced** a wider pathway. Change one dial and something else changes with it. Watchers find that out before movers do.

→ GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Do your zigzag with two dials changed at once: slow **and** low, or fast **and** small.

Which pairs work together, and which pair fights? Most classes find fast and small comfortable, and slow and strong surprisingly difficult to hold for a whole crossing.

UNIT 1 - TOPIC 1.4

New apparatus, same control

■ THE EQUIPMENT YOU NEED

One bench, two hoops, one mat, four cones. **A teacher sets out and tests every piece before the lesson begins.**

STAY SAFE

Apparatus changes what a mistake costs, so three rules are not negotiable.

- 1 An adult sets out and tests every bench, mat and hoop. You never move apparatus into place yourself, and you never move it while somebody is using it.
- 2 One mover on a piece of apparatus at a time. Wait behind the cone, not beside the bench.
- 3 Any wobble at all in a bench or a mat: stop, step off, tell an adult. Do not test it again to see whether it does it twice.

DO YOU REMEMBER?

From 1.3, name the four dials you can change without changing the movement.

WHAT HAPPENED

Tuft has a beautiful smooth sequence on the floor: run, jump, land, turn. He has practised it for two lessons and it has no stops in it at all.

Rowan puts a bench across the middle of it.

Tuft runs, arrives at the bench, stops completely, climbs onto it carefully, gets off the other side, and then does his jump and his turn.

Every movement is still there. The sequence has gone.

► Learn

A movement you can only do on an empty floor is only half learned.

Apparatus is the equipment you move on, over and through: benches, mats, hoops, ropes, cones. When the apparatus changes, three things change with it.

WHAT CHANGES	WHAT IT DOES TO YOUR MOVEMENT
The surface	A bench is narrow, so your feet must land in a line, not side by side
The height	Coming down from a bench is faster than coming down from a jump, so you need more bend in the knees
The shape of the space	A hoop decides where your feet go. You cannot choose your own spot any more

Tuft did not lose his control. He lost his **adaptation**: the small changes that let the same movement work on a new surface. And adaptation is practised exactly the way 1.1 said, one thing at a time.

The rule for the whole topic is short. **Keep the movement. Change the detail.**

GROUND 1.4 · THE SAME SEQUENCE, WITH APPARATUS IN IT

start bench hoop hoop mat

One route, four pieces of apparatus. The bench is narrow so the feet land in a line. The two hoops decide where each foot goes. The shaded square is the mat, which is where the sequence finishes. The crosses are cones marking where the next mover waits.

✧ DID YOU KNOW?

A gymnastics balance beam used in competition is **10 centimetres wide**. It is 5 metres long and it stands 1.25 metres above the floor.

Ten centimetres is about the length of your thumb and your first finger together. Put your hands out and look at it, because that is the surface a gymnast runs, turns and somersaults on.

They did not learn any of that on a beam. They learned it on a line chalked on the floor, then on a bench, then on a low beam, then on a high one. Same movement. Changed detail, four times over.



A chalk line, then a bench, then a beam. Tuft doing exactly what a gymnast does, in the order a gymnast does it. His arms are out level and his eyes are forward in all three. The only thing that changed is what he is standing on.

■ WATCH ME TRY

Tuft goes back to his run, jump, land, turn sequence with the bench in it, and changes one detail at a time.

Attempt 1. He runs at the bench and stops. *The problem is the arrival, not the bench.*

Attempt 2. He shortens his run-up by two paces so he arrives at the bench on the correct foot. He steps up, then down, then stops. *Better. One stop left, on the way down.*

Attempt 3. He comes off the bench into the jump instead of landing first, and bends his knees more because the bench has given him extra height. *No stops.*

Same four movements he had two lessons ago. Two small details changed: a shorter run-up and a deeper knee bend.



Coming off the bench into the jump. Tuft has not landed on the floor first. Look at his knees: they are bending more than they did on the flat, because the bench gave him extra height to absorb.

• YOUR TURN

- 1 Take the sequence you built in 1.2. Add **one** piece of apparatus to it. Write which piece, and where.

The apparatus I added is _____

I put it

2 Run it three times and write what you changed each time. Change one detail per go, as Tuft did.

GO	THE ONE DETAIL I CHANGED	ANY STOPS?
1	_____	_____
2	_____	_____
3	_____	_____

3 Which of the three things in the table changed most for you? Tick one.

- ☐ the surface, because my feet had to land differently
- ☐ the height, because I came down faster
- ☐ the shape of the space, because the apparatus chose where I went

4 Draw the ground you used, with the apparatus on it. Use a rectangle for a bench, a circle for a hoop, a shaded square for a mat, and a dashed line for your route.

OUR GROUND, WITH THE APPARATUS ON IT

▲ TRACK CHALLENGE

Swap grounds with another three. Perform **their** apparatus sequence, from their drawing only, without them telling you anything.

Then tell them the one detail you had to change to make it work on your body. It will not be the same detail they changed, and that is the interesting bit: two bodies adapt the same route differently.

The meadow games

Six friends, three jobs, one sequence each.

This is everything from the Cinder Track at once. You will build a sequence, practise one thing in it until it is smooth, set it on apparatus, perform it at two different dynamics, and have a watcher describe it back to you. Your work is finished when the watcher's description matches what you meant to do.

A MEADOW GAMES SEQUENCE IS GOOD WHEN	IT IS WEAK WHEN
it has three movements and no stop between them	it is three movements with a rest in the middle
it uses at least one piece of apparatus	it stays on the flat floor where it is easy
it can be performed fast and slow on purpose	it only has one speed
a watcher can describe it without asking you	you have to explain it first
it finishes in a balance you could hold to a count of three	it finishes by running out of control



The meadow games. All six of them, three performing and three watching, and the watchers have the pencils. Nobody is being marked. Everybody is being described.

THE MEADOW GAMES · THE FIVE STEPS

- 1 **Build it.** Three movements, two joins, at least one piece of apparatus. Draw the ground before you move.
- 2 **Smooth it.** Choose one thing to change and practise it ten times, as in 1.1. Your timer counts the wobbles.
- 3 **Set the dials.** Perform the whole sequence fast, then slow. Both on purpose. Both held all the way through.
- 4 **Be described.** A watcher writes down every movement, both joins and the dynamics, without speaking to you.
- 5 **Compare.** Read what the watcher wrote beside what you meant. Where they differ, the sequence is not clear yet, not the watcher.

What good looks like: their description and your plan say the same thing.

Step 5 is the one that matters, and it is the one everybody wants to argue about. If the watcher wrote "then she sort of stopped and did a turn", you did stop. The watcher is not being unfair. They are being a mirror, which is the most useful thing a person can be.

Our sequence, written down before we move

OUR MEADOW GAMES SEQUENCE

1

2

3

Apparatus we used, and where we put it:

OUR GROUND, DRAWN BEFORE WE MOVED

WHAT THE WATCHER WROTE AFTERWARDS

* WILLOW'S OWN NOTES

Three movements: a run, a jump off the bench, and a turn to a still balance.

Join 1 was clean. Join 2 had a small step in it that I do not think was planned.

Fast go: held all the way. Slow go: slowed for the run, then went back to normal speed after the bench.

Finished in a balance and held it past three.

That is what a full description looks like. It names the movements, judges both joins separately, checks both dynamics, and says what the finish did. Not one word of it says whether Willow enjoyed it.

How did it go?

Colour one ring in each row: green for yes, amber for nearly, red for not yet. Answer for today, not for your best ever go.

AT THE CINDER TRACK	YES / NEARLY / NOT YET
I practised one movement with one thing to change	☐ ☐ ☐
My tenth go was smoother than my first	☐ ☐ ☐
I joined three movements with no stop in the middle	☐ ☐ ☐
I changed a dial on purpose and kept it there all the way	☐ ☐ ☐
I kept my control when apparatus was added	☐ ☐ ☐
As a watcher, I said what I saw instead of saying "good"	☐ ☐ ☐
As a timer, I read out the number that was really on the watch	☐ ☐ ☐

The two rows about being a watcher and a timer are worth as much as the five about moving. A class where nobody watches properly is a class where nobody

improves, because there is no way to find out whether anything changed.

□ LOOK WHAT I CAN DO

- ☐ practise one movement on purpose, with one thing to change
- ☐ say what got smoother, using words about my body and not about my feelings
- ☐ join three movements into a sequence with no stop at either join
- ☐ name the four dials: speed, level, size and force
- ☐ perform the same movement at two different dynamics, deliberately
- ☐ keep my control when a bench, a hoop or a mat is added
- ☐ describe somebody else's movement so they know exactly what they did
- ☐ read a stopwatch out honestly, even when the number is disappointing

Words we used

Sixteen words. You used every one of them at the Cinder Track.

WORD	WHAT IT MEANS
practice	Repeating a movement with one thing you are trying to change. The noun: <i>a good practice</i> .
practise	To do that repeating. The verb: <i>I practise my landing</i> .
refine	To make a movement you can already do better, in small steps.
smooth	A movement with no wasted wobble, no extra step and no arm shooting out to save it.
wobble	Any small loss of balance that the body has to correct. Countable, which is why the timer counts them.
sequence	Two or more movements joined so that there is no stop in the middle.

WORD	WHAT IT MEANS
join	The place where one movement becomes the next. The only new work in a sequence.
dynamics	The way a movement is done: its speed, level, size and force.
speed	How quickly a movement happens. One of the four dials.
level	How high or low the body is: on the toes, upright, or close to the floor.
force	How strong or how light a movement is.
pathway	The shape of the route a body travels: straight, curved or zigzag.
apparatus	The equipment you move on, over and through: benches, mats, hoops, ropes.
adapt	To change small details of a movement so it still works on new ground.
control	Ending a movement where and how you meant to, every time and not by luck.
coordination	Getting different parts of the body to work together in the right order.

The three jobs

JOB	IN ONE LINE
mover	Does the movement, properly, as many times as the task asks.
timer	Counts or times, and says the real number out loud.
watcher	Looks at one thing, and says what they saw, not whether they liked it.

Answers for Unit 1

Some tasks in this unit have one right answer. Most do not, because a movement task is answered with a body and no two bodies answer it the same way. Where there is no single answer, this page says what a good answer must contain instead. Teachers can mark from the right-hand column without having seen the lesson.

1.1 Making a movement smoother

TASK	ANSWER, OR WHAT A GOOD ANSWER CONTAINS
Practise 1, choose a movement and one thing to change	The movement must be one the pupil can already do. The one thing must be about the body , and specific: "land with bent knees", "keep my hands still", "look ahead". Reject "jump better", "be smoother" and "try harder", which name no body part and cannot be watched.
Practise 2, the table of ten goes	Four rows completed, from goes 1, 4, 7 and 10. The watcher's column must describe the one chosen thing each time, not the whole movement. A wobble count is a number, not a word.
Practise 3, which is true	Any of the three boxes may be ticked truthfully. Ticking the third box, "worse, because I got tired", is a correct and useful answer and must not be marked down.
Practise 4, what you would do differently	Accept anything that reduces the load or improves the conditions: fewer goes, a rest between goes, practising earlier in the lesson, a shorter run-up.

1.2 Joining movements together

TASK	ANSWER, OR WHAT A GOOD ANSWER CONTAINS
Do you remember, the three things that make a practice work	One thing to change · a way to tell · enough goes. All three needed. Accept "a watcher" or "a number" for the second, and "about ten" for the third.
Practise 1, a sequence of three	Three movements chosen from the list, written in the order they will be performed. Two joins marked with an arrow.
Practise 2, the weaker join	A named join, 1 or 2, for each of the three goes, with what went wrong at it. A pupil who writes the whole sequence again instead of naming the join has not done the task.
Practise 3, draw the route	Must use the four marks correctly: a dashed line for the route, a ring at the start and at the finish, a short upright mark at each of the two joins.
Practise 4, ticks	All three may be true. The third, "I could have added a fourth movement", is the strongest evidence that both joins worked, because it means the sequence still had speed at the end.
Track challenge	Passed only when a watcher who has not seen it lists all three movements and both joins without asking a question.

1.3 Fast, slow, high, low

TASK	ANSWER, OR WHAT A GOOD ANSWER CONTAINS
Practise 1, four timed goes	Four times recorded, and a yes or no for each on whether the dial was held all the way. Expect the slow go to be the one that fails.
Practise 2, the two furthest apart	Almost always the fast go and the slow go. Any two goes are acceptable if the pupil has read their own times correctly.
Practise 3, the hardest one again	A second time for the same setting. It should be more extreme than the first: slower, or lower. If it is not, the pupil has recorded honestly, which still counts.
Practise 4, match the instruction to the dial	"Like a heavy giant" = force . "As small as a mouse" = size . "So slowly I cannot see you moving" = speed . "On your toes with your arms stretched up" = level .
Go a little further, two dials at once	Accept any pairing with a reason. Fast and small usually sits comfortably; slow and strong is genuinely hard to hold for a full crossing, and noticing that is the point.

1.4 New apparatus, same control

TASK	ANSWER, OR WHAT A GOOD ANSWER CONTAINS
Do you remember, the four dials	Speed • level • size • force . All four needed, in any order.
Practise 1, add one piece of apparatus	One piece only, named, with where it was placed in the sequence. A pupil who adds three has made a new sequence rather than adapted one.
Practise 2, one detail per go	Three rows, each naming one detail, and a yes or no for stops. Look for the detail getting smaller across the three goes: a shorter run-up, then a deeper knee bend, then a shoulder turn.
Practise 3, which changed most	Any of the three boxes, with the pupil's own apparatus matching their choice. A bench should point to the surface or the height; a hoop should point to the shape of the space.
Practise 4, draw the ground	Rectangle for a bench, circle for a hoop, shaded square for a mat, dashed line for the route. The drawing must match the sequence they actually performed.
Track challenge, swap grounds	Passed when the pupils perform another group's sequence from the drawing alone, and can name the one detail they personally had to change.

The meadow games

STEP	WHAT A FINISHED PROJECT LOOKS LIKE
1 Build it	Three movements, two joins, at least one piece of apparatus, and the ground drawn before anybody moved.
2 Smooth it	Ten goes on one chosen detail, with a wobble count that falls, or an honest note saying why it did not.
3 Set the dials	The whole sequence performed fast and slow, each held from start to finish.
4 Be described	A watcher's written description naming all three movements, both joins, and both dynamics.
5 Compare	The plan and the description placed side by side, with the differences named. Finding a difference is a pass, not a fail. A group that finds none has usually not looked.

Where the facts came from

Every fact in a *Did you know?* panel was checked against the source named here on 2026-08-10. Nothing in this unit is recalled or estimated.

WHERE IT APPEARS	THE CLAIM	CHECKED AGAINST
1.1 <i>Did you know?</i>	Rosa Mota won the Olympic marathon for Portugal in Seoul in 1988 in 2 hours 25 minutes 40 seconds, by 13 seconds; world title Rome 1987; European titles 1982, 1986 and 1990	en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Rosa_Mota
1.2 <i>Did you know?</i>	The triple jump is a hop, then a step, then a jump, in one continuous run, landing on the take-off foot for the hop and the other foot for the step	en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Triple_jump , quoting the World Athletics rule
1.2 <i>Did you know?</i>	Nelson Évora won Olympic gold in the triple jump for Portugal in Beijing in 2008	en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Nelson_Évora

WHERE IT APPEARS	THE CLAIM	CHECKED AGAINST
1.3 <i>Did you know?</i>	A European hare can run at about 70 kilometres an hour, and escapes by outrunning predators in the open	en.wikipedia.org/wiki/European_hare
1.4 <i>Did you know?</i>	A competition gymnastics balance beam is 10 centimetres wide, 5 metres long and 1.25 metres above the floor	en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Balance_beam , quoting the FIG Apparatus Norms

For teachers

This section is written to the teacher, not to the pupil. It is here because every Prime Book carries it, and because a Physical Education unit is impossible to run from the pupil pages alone: the tasks assume groups of three, a checked space and apparatus an adult has set out.

What this unit is for

Unit 1 covers the four Year 3 *Moving Well* objectives from the Year 3 Physical Education scheme of work: refining basic movement skills through practice (1.1), performing them sequentially (1.2), control and coordination with varied space, speed and dynamics (1.3), and adapting to contexts, apparatus and equipment (1.4).

It deliberately does **not** re-teach the movements themselves. Year 1 taught running, jumping, hopping, skipping, landing, stopping, throwing and balancing, and Year 3 assumes them. If a pupil cannot yet land softly or stop where they meant to, the Year 1 material is the right place to go, not a slower version of this unit.

The pedagogical spine

The unit rests on one move: **the class is split into mover, timer and watcher, and the jobs rotate.** Everything else follows from it.

- It makes the scheme's observation and feedback objectives practisable in Year 3 rather than deferred to a written test.
- It gives every pupil a number or a description that is about their **own** earlier attempt, which is the only comparison this book permits.
- It occupies the two pupils who are not moving, which is what usually goes wrong in a primary Physical Education lesson.

Groups of three are therefore not a suggestion. A pair loses the watcher, and the watcher is where the learning is.

Timing

Four topics and a project fill about six lessons of 45 minutes for most classes. Topic 1.1 is the one to give extra time: ten purposeful repetitions takes longer than teachers expect, and cutting it to four removes the evidence the rest of the unit depends on.

A practical note on the timetable. A lesson that starts at **14:30** in Portugal in September is often the hottest part of the afternoon, and topic 1.3 asks pupils to hold a fast setting for a full crossing. Where the hall is warm or the outdoor ground is in full sun, run 1.3 in a morning slot and keep the afternoon for 1.1, which is mostly standing still and watching.

Assessment

Assess from the *Look what I can do* list and the project's step 5 comparison, not from the times. A slow pupil who holds a dial exactly where they put it has met 1.3. A fast pupil who cannot slow down has not.

The Input names three assessment points across the year, one per term. Those become three review spreads in the complete book and are not part of this unit.

Adaptations

- **Distances, heights and timings are all adjustable.** The objective is control, not size. Shorten the lane, lower the apparatus, allow a longer run-up.

- **A pupil who cannot travel** takes the same four dials into a seated or supported movement: an arm pathway can be fast, slow, high, low, large, small, strong or light exactly as a run can.
- **A pupil who cannot write** dictates the watcher's description to a partner, or draws the ground instead. The description matters; the handwriting does not.
- **Apparatus is set out and tested by an adult**, always. The orange *Stay safe* panel in 1.4 is written to the pupil, but the responsibility is the teacher's.

What usually goes wrong, and what to do about it

Six things go wrong in this unit in almost every class. None of them is a sign that the unit is too hard, and five of the six are the lesson working rather than failing.

WHAT YOU WILL SEE	WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING	WHAT TO DO
A pupil does ten repetitions that all look the same	They are repeating, not practising. Nothing was chosen to change	Send them back to step 3 of <i>How every task runs</i> : say the one thing out loud, in one short sentence, before the next go
The watcher says "that was good"	The commonest failure in the unit, and the hardest to break. Judging is easier than describing	Give the watcher one body part to look at and nothing else. Hands. Knees. Feet. Take the whole movement away from them
The timer's numbers drift kinder as the lesson goes on	They are trying to be encouraging, and they have not yet understood that the number is the mover's evidence	Read the <i>Did you know?</i> on the ground-rules page together. A kind number is a useless number
A pupil is much slower than the rest and knows it	Almost always a pupil comparing across the class, which this book never asks for	Point at their own first go. Every comparison in this unit is against their own earlier attempt, and that is not a soft option: it is harder to beat yourself
Fixing one join in 1.2 makes a second join fall apart	The second fault was hiding behind the first stop. This is normal and it is worth saying so out loud	Attempt 2 of the worked example in 1.2 is exactly this. It is progress, not going backwards

WHAT YOU WILL SEE	WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING	WHAT TO DO
A smooth floor sequence collapses the moment a bench appears in 1.4	Adaptation has not been practised, which is precisely what 1.4 is for	Shorten the run-up first, before anything else. It is the single change that fixes most of them

If you only have three lessons

Where time is short, teach **1.1 and 1.2 properly** and treat 1.3 and 1.4 as one combined lesson. Do not cut 1.1: it carries the practice method that every later topic depends on, and a class that has not done ten purposeful repetitions has no evidence to reason from in 1.2, 1.3 or 1.4.

If the hall is unavailable, all four topics run outdoors on any marked ground. Only 1.4 needs apparatus, and a chalked line, a low wall and two hoops will carry it if benches and mats cannot be set out.

Free resources for this unit

Both addresses were opened and read on 2026-08-10. Neither needs an account and neither charges. They are printed here, in the teacher section, rather than as square codes on a pupil page: both are **teacher** resource libraries, so a code inviting an eight-year-old to open one was the wrong place for them.

ADDRESS	WHAT IS THERE, AND WHY IT FITS THIS UNIT
youthsporttrust.org/free-resources	Free primary physical education resources from the Youth Sport Trust, a registered charity in the United Kingdom. The 60 Second Physical Activity Challenges are built on the principle of topic 1.1: a pupil measures themselves against their own last attempt. Registration is offered but not required.
playworks.org/game-library	A free library of playground and hall games from Playworks, a charity in the United States, filterable by age, group size, space, equipment and length. Useful for topic 1.4, which needs many different grounds. Every game carries inclusive adaptations. Note that the site uses United States year labels and spellings.

Three big days, three terms

The plan on the *year at a glance* page sets an Athletics Day at the end of term 1, a Football Day at the end of term 2 and a Multi-sports Day at the end of term 3. Unit 1 feeds all three, and the table on that page says which topic feeds which activity. Two practical notes:

- **Confirm the dates against the school calendar** before the year starts. A term end moves more often than a syllabus does.

- **The three days are assessment opportunities, not competitions.** Every activity

on them can be scored against a pupil's own earlier attempt, which is the only comparison this book permits.